At the beginning of January 2014, Dieudonné was to begin a grand tour of France to disseminate his hate propaganda from town to town. Manuel Valls, then the interior minister (he would become prime minister in April that year) issued orders and guidelines to mayors and *préfets* (local government commissioners) to ban his shows as public safety risks. Moreover, the police raided the agitator's home outside Paris and found potential evidence of tax evasion or money laundering. What happened next? While many citizens congratulated the minister for acting decisively against a dangerous agitator, many others criticized him for "curbing free speech and expression" in line with his own "politically correct" agenga. In fact, Valls, who was then the most popular politician in the country and most popular minister in François Hollande's socialist administration, dropped by ten points in the polls, from an average 60% of positive opinion to an average 50%. Even more revealing and disturbing: only 38% of the French approved of the ban, while 32% opposed it, and 64% said that Dieudonné and Valls were in fact "comforting each other."[2]

The second ominous event took place on January 26, 2014, amidst a rightwing or populist rally against the François Hollande administration, dubbed "Jour de Colère" (Day of anger), that attracted at least 20,000 people and possibly twice as many. Some of the demonstrators—obvious supporters of Dieudonné—repeatedly shouted antisemitic slogans: "Jew, France does not belong to you" and "The Holocaust is just a hoax." Other demonstrators did not seem disturbed by the chanting, nor did the rally's organizers bother to call the rogues to order, as Ivan Rioufol, a conservative commentator, observed the next day in the newspaper *Le Figaro*.[3]

True enough, Islamic militant groups in France have repeatedly voiced similar and even worse slogans for years during street demonstrations. However, since they were doing it in Arabic rather than French, they were largely unnoticed by the media, if not the police. And people debating the issue of resurgent antisemitism could resort in good faith to the reassuring remark that "after all, Nazis were not marching in Paris." Faced with the Jour de Colère rally, even die-hard optimists had to recognize that this is no longer true. Nazis *were* marching in Paris, unchecked—postmodern Nazis, to be sure: no brown shirts. But Nazis nevertheless—people steeped in anti-Jewish paranoia and eager to spread it everywhere. And they seemed to be drawn from every corner of contemporary French society, Left and the Right alike, from the native, Christian European majority as well as the non-European and largely non-Christian immigrant minorities.

Antisemitism is often connected to radical politics, and France, a country in crisis, is ripe for change because classic politics seem to have failed.

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